

# Long distance Arab shipping in the 9th century Indian Ocean: recent shipwreck evidence from Southeast Asia

John Guy\*

The Metropolitan Museum of Art, 1000 Fifth Avenue, New York, NY 10028, USA

**The present article examines two of the earliest shipwrecks and their cargoes belonging to long distance trade recovered in Southeast Asia as a key to understanding the radical changes that were taking place in the Indian Ocean around the beginning of the 9th century CE. The *Belitung* (Tang) shipwreck was reported in 1998, in the western Java Sea. In 2014, a second Arab dhow was discovered, in the saturated landscape of reclaimed mangrove on the northern shore of the Gulf of Thailand. Both proved to be of seminal importance: the *Belitung* cargo consisted of the largest assemblage of late Tang era artefacts ever recovered, whilst the *Phanom Surin* shipwreck revealed the first finding of Gulf storage jars in Southeast Asia, and the first Pallavi inscription recorded from the region. These are the only securely recorded instances of medieval ships of West Asian design and probable origin being recovered archaeologically in Southeast Asia.**

**Keywords:** Arab dhow, *Belitung*, Pahlavi inscription, *Phanom Surin*, Srivijaya.

## Introduction

HERE we examine two shipwrecks recovered in the last 20 years, one in the western Java Sea in 1998, the other in the Gulf of Thailand in 2013. These are known as the *Belitung* (Tang) and *Phanom Surin* shipwrecks respectively. Both proved to be large ocean sailing hardwood timber vessels of stitched hull construction, identifying them as dhows, belonging to the Arab ship building tradition (Figure 1). Both employ hardwoods for their hulls and masts, and softwoods for replaceable decking and fittings. The softwood elements, and the stitching of the hull's timbers, would have demanded regular refreshment, especially for vessels spending time in tropical waters. In the case of the *Belitung*, located in the warm waters of the Java Sea, only the major timbers survive, whilst *Phanom Surin* was lodged in saturated mangrove silt which has provided an oxygen-free environment ensuring that much of the original coir stitching has survived, along with rigging ropes and other organic mate-

rial (Figure 2). Both vessels contained evidence of cargo indicative of long-distance trade that linked them to both the Persian Gulf and south China<sup>1,2</sup>.

The evidence proffered by these two shipwrecks and their cargoes is of utmost importance for our understanding of long distance maritime trade and Asian exchange systems in the wider Indian Ocean world in the later first millennium CE. At last we are able to demonstrate archaeologically what the Arab and Persian geographers and travel commentators wrote of in this period: direct trade between the Abbasid ports in the Gulf and those of south China. Further, two ship's cargoes provide a unique opportunity to understand in a more nuanced way the nature of this exchange system. To focus specifically on the less than a half century in which these two shipwrecks were operating, in my view, from the late 8th to second quarter of the 9th century CE, we have startling new evidence for the exponential expansion of commodity trade. In the case of China, this is the industrialization, on a scale not witnessed before, of the production of glazed ceramics for export market.

The *Belitung* shipwreck was first reported by Indonesian fishermen in shallow waters offshore from Belitung Island, near Bangka, in the western Java Sea in 1998. It has been widely reported and more recently has been the subject of two exhibitions<sup>3</sup>. Then, in 2013, a second Arab dhow was discovered, in the saturated landscape of reclaimed mangrove on the northern shore of the Gulf of Thailand<sup>4</sup>. These are the only securely recorded instances of medieval ships of West Asian design and probable origin being recovered archaeologically in Southeast Asia.

Prior to the discovery of these two vessels, we already had a rich literature that chronicled that trade and described the routes navigated. These sources, principally in Arabic and Persian, provide the earliest written descriptions of the journey to be undertaken by sea from ports of the Persian Gulf to those of southern China. Arabic sources of the mid-9th to mid-10th century CE make clear that the dominant mercantile presence in this burgeoning trade was from the gulf region. The Arab Baghdadi geographer Mas'udi (d. 956) summed up much of this in his *Muruj adh-dhahab wa ma'adin al-jawhar* ('meadows of gold and mines of gems') knowledge, but two mid-9th

\*e-mail: john.guy@metmuseum.org







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